

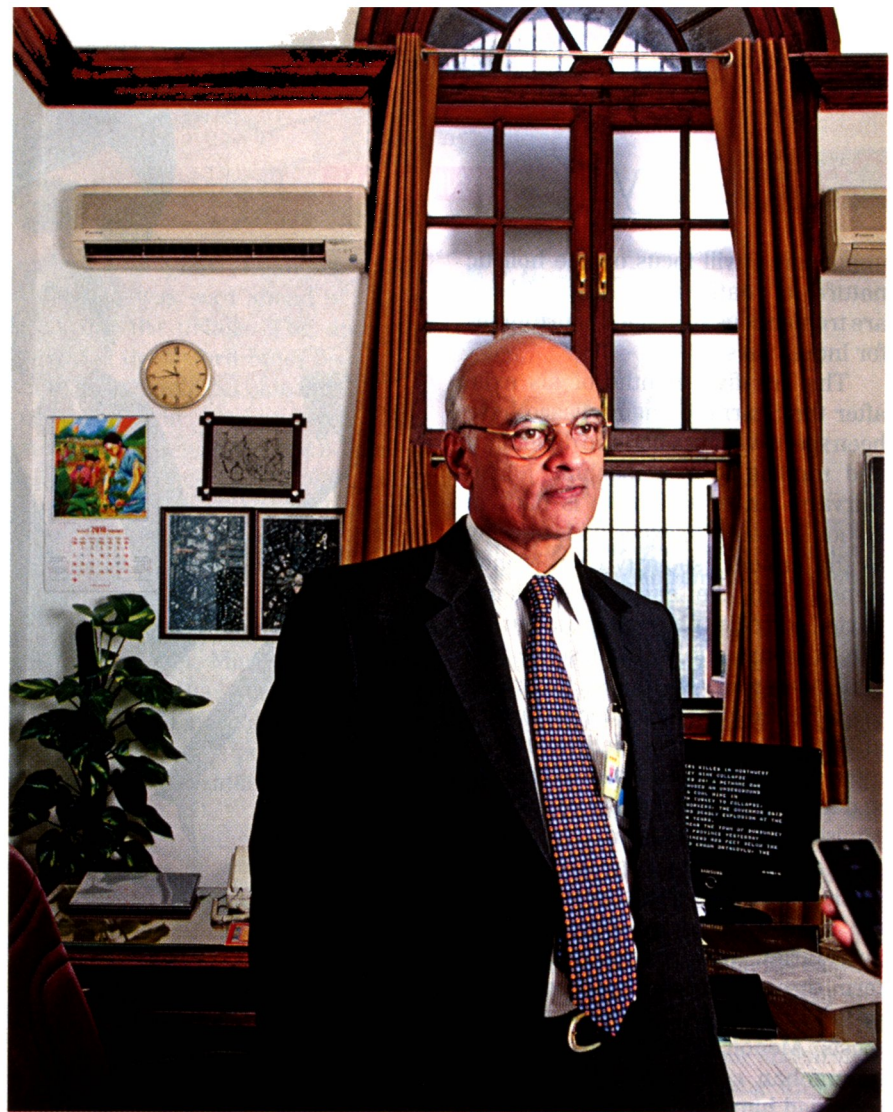
National Rural Health Mission.

Nair's USP lies in striking a conciliatory tone in the most difficult circumstances. However, if angry, he can be uncompromising. His latest baby is an ambitious project to bring in a Right to Essential Services, with a pilot project set to be rolled out in Delhi in April 2010, where the citizens will get an assurance from the government that services like a driving licence, a voter ID card, a birth or a death certificate is provided in a time-bound manner and if the officials fail to deliver on time, they will have to pay a fine.

Nair's also ensures a harmonious atmosphere within the PMO. Insiders say that whenever he recommends a name to the prime minister for selection or an extension for an official, the file invariably gets the prime minister's nod. His importance also emanates from his years of experience which helps him tide over thorny issues through personal connections. He is also a walking encyclopedia on who can be tapped for what; this was visible when he rallied support for the Indo-US nuclear deal. Even now when it requires for the prime minister to sound out key opposition leaders on major policy issues, it is Nair who is used as a sounding board. Nair is equally comfortable with India Inc, and insiders believe that when it comes to meeting the Ambani brothers or settling the telecom woes of operators it is Nair who is asked to chip in, and he is good at giving a patient hearing without committing to anything.

Another important quality is that he can monitor and push things with any ministry without ruffling feathers with

UNDER NAIR, THE PMO UNVEILED A delivery monitoring mechanism that is tasked with carrying out the PM's grass-roots agenda.



HEMANT CHAWLA/www.indiatodayimages.com

his persuasive style, remarks a senior government official. Insiders say it is Nair who helps the prime minister make difficult decisions, while he refuses to say so, Nair is the hidden hand behind many decisions that have made the Manmohan PMO look more decisive. For instance when Chemicals and Fertilizers Minister M. K. Azhagiri was adamant on not diluting the urea subsidy and opposed the proposal of a nutrition-based subsidy, Nair recommended that the prime minister should stand by the recommendations of the Group of Ministers on a nutrition-based subsidy.

Over the Prime Minister's Special Envoy on Climate Change Shyam Saran's resignation too, Nair read Manmohan's mind and quickly cleared the file. He knows that the prime minister trusts him and that has been his survival mantra. A devout Hindu, he never misses the annual pilgrimage to Sabarimala and Guruvayur. As a senior official describes him, "He makes even the most difficult decisions seem so simple and that is the importance of Mr Nair."

■ S.S. Menon

NATIONAL SECURITY ADVISER

THE SUPER DIPLOMAT

Despite the setback at Sharm el-Sheikh, Menon is back as NSA, an indication of just how much the PM values his diplomatic skills and general worldview

It is early morning and India's national security czar is already reviewing the day's intelligence reports with close advisers ahead of a briefing for the prime minister. Three weeks into his job, Shiv Shankar Menon oozes confidence and says he feels privileged to be part of Manmohan's think tank. "The amount of experience and intellectual depth that he brings to any problem that you take to him is amazing and you leave with a better understanding of the problem," says Menon about his boss. "The neighbourhood is very important, China is very